MK FRAUD INSIGHTS

FRAUD READINESS · ESSENTIAL

Fraud Readiness Report

Fictional Retail Group (extensive unanswered information)

Assessment reference FX-P5

12 November 2026

Confidential. Prepared for the management of Fictional Retail Group (extensive unanswered information).

Fictional prototype for MK review. The organisation is fictional, calculated figures are labelled test results, and this is not a customer report or a certified paid report.

About this report

This report sets out what the group's own answers establish about its fraud controls, what remains unknown, what that means for management, and what should happen first. It begins with the overall position and the patterns behind it, develops the findings that deserve leadership attention, shows how fraud could exploit them, and closes with the first responses and a ninety-day plan. The supporting workbook carries the complete registers and the detailed control specifications.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The group's fraud framework stops short of its operations, and several of the functions that run them do not know how their own controls work

On its own answers, the group reports the core controls in place for 46 of the 106 fraud scenarios that apply to a retail and wholesale business of its size, and a core control reported as a gap in 58. For a further two scenarios the core answers are outstanding. In fraud governance, finance and banking, and detection and response, every core control is reported in place. In third parties, people and payroll, customers, assets and stock, and digital channels, almost every core control is reported as a gap.

The environment is therefore sharply uneven. The group has ownership of fraud risk, finance and banking controls and a way to report and investigate concerns. What it has not yet done is carry that discipline into the processes where suppliers and staff are paid, customers receive credit and refunds, stock is held and instructions arrive by email, phone and video.

A second feature sets this assessment apart. Seven questions put to the functions that run these processes came back as "not known", from five different functions, including risk, payroll, finance and sales. Those answers are not treated as weaknesses, and nothing is concluded from them. They do, however, show that in several places the people closest to a control cannot say whether it operates, which is itself something management needs to know.

Four patterns explain the position. Information about the controls is missing where it should be held; the framework at the centre has not reached the operations; changes to bank details, customer details and identity are accepted on the requester's word across four areas; and no independent review examines procurement or payroll.

In fraud terms, the patterns open well-practised routes to loss. A supplier's bank details can be changed and confirmed through the fraudster's own number. Credit can be granted on documents checked only when something looks wrong. Refunds can be raised and approved by the same person below a threshold, and an employee in a sensitive role can go years without anyone else doing their work. Because nobody looks across procurement or payroll, these schemes would be hard to see from inside the processes where they occur.

Management's first step is to close the information gaps and assign ownership. Every outstanding question should be assigned to a named person, answered or recorded as an open item within the first thirty days. Each operating area should have an accountable

executive. The first controls to design are those that close the most practised routes: confirming supplier bank changes through details already on file, a call-back that holds whatever a caller appears to be, the monthly senior review of supplier payments, verification of credit applications with their source, block leave for every sensitive role, and verification of customer detail changes away from sales.

This summary sets out what the answers establish, what remains unknown and what the group should do first.

WHAT THE ASSESSMENT ESTABLISHES

CALCULATED TEST RESULT

55.1 of 100 TEST FIXTURE

The arithmetic result of the answers under the method's scoring frame, shown for traceability. It carries no band.

UNRESOLVED INCONSISTENCIES

None found

None found in the 1 pair of answers compared. Most related practices were not asked, so this is not a finding that every answer is consistent.

PROVISIONAL MANAGEMENT INTERPRETATION

58 with a control reported as a gap

On its own answers, the organisation reports the core control in place for 46 of the 106 fraud scenarios that apply; 2 cannot yet be read because answers are outstanding; and 58 have a core control reported as a gap.

APPROVED READINESS CONCLUSION

None issued

MK states its readiness conclusion here under its approved readiness method. Until then the report sets out what the answers establish.

The four statements are kept separate: the calculated result is arithmetic, the inconsistencies and the interpretation come from the organisation's own answers, and the readiness conclusion is MK's.

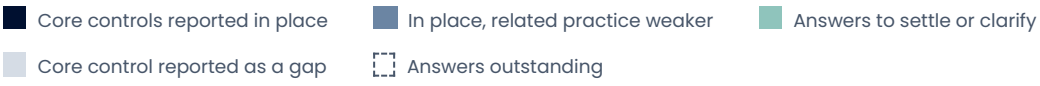
READINESS PROFILE

The centre holds, the operating areas are open, and the unknowns sit inside both

The profile shows how the fraud scenarios in each of the ten areas divide between controls reported in place, controls reported as gaps and answers still outstanding. In three areas every core control is reported in place: fraud governance and accountability, finance, banking and financial reporting and detection, speak-up and response. In five areas nearly every core control is reported as a gap: third parties and supply chain, people, payroll and insider risk, customers, revenue and products, assets, cash and inventory and digital, cyber-enabled and identity fraud.

READINESS PROFILE: FRAUD SCENARIOS BY AREA

AREA	SCENARIOS THAT APPLY	CORE CONTROLS IN PLACE	TEST FIGURE
Fraud governance and accountability		12 of 12	90.0
Fraud risk assessment		5 of 6	90.0
Ethics, integrity and anti-corruption		9 of 10	81.0
Third parties and supply chain		0 of 13	19.3
People, payroll and insider risk		0 of 11	26.4
Finance, banking and financial reporting		12 of 12	92.5
Customers, revenue and products		0 of 10	25.0
Assets, cash and inventory		0 of 10	21.1
Digital, cyber-enabled and identity fraud		0 of 14	18.6
Detection, speak-up and response		8 of 8	86.7



Each bar shows the fraud scenarios in the method that apply to the organisation in that area, by what its answers report about the controls that stop them. Areas appear in the method's order. Test figures are the calculated result for each area, shown for traceability; they are not scores and carry no band.

The open areas are large, with 14 gaps in digital channels, 13 in third parties and 11 in people and payroll. The fraud risk assessment would sit with the central areas but for answers that its own function could not give, about whether process owners take part and whether the assessment is updated when the business changes.

The shape is that of a programme built from the centre outward that has not yet reached the operations, with gaps in knowledge as well as in controls. The response should therefore start by establishing what the functions know, so that the controls the group builds rest on facts rather than assumptions.

WHAT IS DRIVING THE POSITION

Four patterns drive the position, and the first is about what the group does not yet know

The profile shows where the gaps and unknowns lie. The patterns below explain why they matter together, and each ends with what it asks of leadership.

ACROSS THE ORGANISATION

Several functions do not hold answers about their own controls

Seven questions came back as “not known” from five functions. Risk and investigations could not say whether process owners take part in the risk assessment or whether it is updated when the business changes. Payroll could not say whether payroll data is analysed, finance whether customer payments are matched to invoices, sales whether refunds go back to the original source or whether the asset register is checked physically, and compliance whether the risk of retaliation against a reporter is assessed.

Each unknown is treated as outstanding, not as a gap. Taken together, though, they show something useful: in several processes the people responsible cannot describe a control that would, if it existed, be routine to them. That is a sign either that the control does not operate or that it operates without its owner knowing, and in both cases management cannot rely on it.

The implication is that the group should require an answer, or a recorded open item with an owner, for each question before the scenarios it affects are ordered and designed.

ACROSS THE ORGANISATION

The framework at the centre has not been carried into the operating processes

Governance, finance and detection are reported as complete, while third parties, people and payroll, customers, assets and digital channels are reported as almost entirely open. The framework tells the group who owns fraud risk and how concerns will be handled. It does not stop a supplier being paid into the wrong account or stock leaving a store; that depends on controls inside the processes, which the answers report as largely absent.

The implication is that the executives who run the operating areas should each own the controls in their processes, supported by the functions that built the framework.

ACROSS THE ORGANISATION

Changes to bank details, customer details and identity are accepted on the requester's word

Across four areas, 13 practices that would verify a request through a route the requester does not control are reported weaker than in place. Supplier bank changes are confirmed through contact details in the request, a familiar voice is accepted, customer and employee changes are not consistently verified with the person concerned, and credit documents are checked only when something looks wrong.

Most payment diversion, impersonation and application fraud succeeds by supplying the confirmation a process asks for. The defence in each case is the same, verification through details already held and a channel the requester did not choose, so the group should design it once and apply it everywhere it is needed.

THIRD PARTIES AND SUPPLY CHAIN · PEOPLE, PAYROLL AND INSIDER RISK

Nothing independent examines procurement or payroll

Independent review of procurement and of payroll are both reported weaker than in place, across third parties and supply chain and people, payroll and insider risk. The senior review of supplier payments is agreed but not working, the payroll review looks only at totals, and payroll's own function could not say whether payroll data is analysed.

Without anyone looking across the payments, fictitious suppliers, split orders and ghost employees can each pass every individual check. Leadership should decide how procurement and payroll will be examined by someone outside those processes.

THE FINDINGS THIS REPORT DEVELOPS

Seven findings show the patterns at work in the processes that move money, goods and credit

The findings below are the scenarios through which each pattern appears most clearly: within each theme, the scenario with more core controls reported absent, or with the most related practices also reported weaker. They follow the method's order of areas, which is not a ranking; The full register of 59 findings is in the supporting workbook.

THIRD PARTIES AND SUPPLY CHAIN

Supplier bank changes can be confirmed through the fraudster's own contact details

Changes to supplier bank details are confirmed, but sometimes using contact details taken from the change request, and a follow-up call from someone who sounds like the supplier's usual contact is accepted.

Both answers describe a confirmation the fraudster controls. When the number comes from the request, the call reaches the person who sent it; when a familiar voice is enough, a cloned voice passes. The control exists in form but does not establish that the supplier asked for the change.

The finance lead should require every change to be confirmed through contact details already on file, by someone other than the person who captured it, whatever a caller appears to be.

POSITION	CORE CONTROL	OWNER	FIRST RESPONSE
A core control reported as a gap	Change confirmed with supplier: partly in place; Familiar caller still verified: not in place	Finance lead	60 days (proposed)

THIRD PARTIES AND SUPPLY CHAIN

The senior review of supplier payments has been agreed but does not run

A monthly senior review of supplier payments is set out but not working. Split orders are not yet monitored in practice, payment data is not reviewed for unusual patterns, and independent review of procurement is only partly in place.

Together these describe a capability the group has decided it needs but has not built: looking at supplier payments as a whole. Without it, purchases split under an approval limit, duplicate invoices and unfamiliar suppliers pass their individual checks unseen.

Because the review is already designed, the task is to make it run, with a named senior manager who does not process payments and a first review covering the previous twelve months.

POSITION	CORE CONTROL	OWNER	FIRST RESPONSE
A core control reported as a gap	Senior review of supplier payments: set out, not yet operating	Finance lead	60 days (proposed)

CUSTOMERS, REVENUE AND PRODUCTS

Credit is granted on documents checked only when something looks wrong

Supporting documents for credit applications are verified only if something looks wrong, and independent approval of credit, bureau checks and the investigation of early defaults are each only partly in place. Finance could not say whether customer payments are matched to invoices.

A check triggered by appearance is the one generated payslips and statements are designed to pass. With early defaults not consistently investigated and payment matching unknown, losses from fraudulent applications would be hard to distinguish from ordinary bad debt.

The finance lead should require the key information in every application to be verified with its source before approval, and should establish whether payments are matched to invoices.

POSITION	CORE CONTROL	OWNER	FIRST RESPONSE
A core control reported as a gap	Application documents verified: partly in place	Finance lead	60 days (proposed)

PEOPLE, PAYROLL AND INSIDER RISK

Block leave reaches most sensitive roles, but not all, and the roles are not fully identified

Most people in sensitive roles take block leave with someone else doing their work. Identifying high-risk roles is only partly in place, separating conflicting duties during cover and avoiding single points of knowledge are set out but not operating, and there is no fair route for concerns or support for staff under financial pressure.

Block leave works only if it reaches the person who would conceal a fraud, and the roles most likely to be missed are those that have grown informally around one individual. Where cover is arranged with conflicting duties, even the leave that is taken may not expose a scheme.

The HR and payroll lead should identify the sensitive roles, keep the list current and require block leave in every one of them, with cover by someone without conflicting duties.

POSITION	CORE CONTROL	OWNER	FIRST RESPONSE
A core control reported as a gap	Block leave required: partly in place	HR and payroll lead	60 days (proposed)

CUSTOMERS, REVENUE AND PRODUCTS

Customer refund and delivery details can be changed by sales staff

Most changes to customer details are verified with the customer, but sales staff can still make them. Defined onboarding is not in place, business customers are only partly verified, and details shared between accounts are not flagged.

A change to a refund account or delivery address is how refunds and goods are redirected. Allowing the people who serve customers to make it removes the second person whose involvement would deter collusion. Where an impostor gains a customer's personal information in the process, the group is the responsible party under POPIA and must report the compromise to the Information Regulator and the customer, as section 22 requires.

The commercial and customer lead should verify every change through details on file and move the change out of sales.

POSITION	CORE CONTROL	OWNER	FIRST RESPONSE
A core control reported as a gap	Customer detail changes verified: partly in place	Commercial and customer lead	60 days (proposed)

PEOPLE, PAYROLL AND INSIDER RISK

Payroll is reviewed only at the level of totals, and nobody could say whether its data is analysed

Someone other than the preparer looks at each payroll run, but only at the totals. Headcount verification is not in place, independent review of payroll is only partly in place, and payroll could not say whether its data is analysed.

A ghost employee or a leaver left on the payroll does not move the totals enough to be noticed. Without headcount verification, data analysis that payroll can confirm, or an independent review, there is no point at which the payroll is compared with the people the group actually employs.

The HR and payroll lead should require a detailed review of each run before payment by someone who did not prepare it, and should establish whether the payroll data is analysed.

POSITION	CORE CONTROL	OWNER	FIRST RESPONSE
A core control reported as a gap	Payroll reviewed by another person: partly in place	HR and payroll lead	In the workbook action register

CUSTOMERS, REVENUE AND PRODUCTS

Refunds are approved independently only when they are large or staff are unsure

Approval of refunds and credit notes by someone other than the processor is sought only for large refunds or when staff are unsure. Receiving returns before credit is not in place, and reviewing refund patterns and reversals after period end is only partly in place. Sales could not say whether refunds go back to the original source.

A refund raised and approved by the same person, below the threshold that triggers approval, is one of the oldest ways to steal from a retailer. If refunds can go to an account other than the original source of payment, the money can be redirected without any record

of a customer.

The commercial and customer lead should require independent approval of every refund and credit note and establish where refunds are paid.

POSITION	CORE CONTROL	OWNER	FIRST RESPONSE
A core control reported as a gap	Refunds approved independently: partly in place	Commercial and customer lead	In the workbook action register

HOW FRAUD EXPOSURE COULD MATERIALISE

The open controls create three practised routes to loss, each hard to see from inside the process

In each pathway below, one weakness provides the opportunity and another delays its discovery. They are plausible sequences built from the answers and MK's scenario library, and they do not suggest that any of these events has occurred.

FRAUD PATHWAY · PEOPLE, PAYROLL AND INSIDER RISK

An employee who is never away sustains a scheme for years

A trusted employee in a sensitive role, such as creditors, payroll or stock, manipulates the records they control. The opportunity is a role that has never been identified as sensitive, so block leave does not reach it and nobody else ever does the work.

The scheme needs continuous attention, which the employee gives by being present for every transaction and every query that could expose it. Where leave is taken, cover by someone with conflicting duties may not see it either. Such frauds are usually discovered by chance, and they are large by the time they are found.

WARNING SIGNS

- An employee in a sensitive role who does not take leave
- Work that only one person understands or is allowed to do
- Queries that are always routed to the same person
- Resistance to rotation or process change

FIRST RESPONSE

Place the work with someone else immediately, review the period's transactions, and preserve the records before the employee is approached.

LASTING CONTROL

Sensitive roles are identified and recorded, and everyone in them takes block leave each year during which someone else does their work.

FRAUD PATHWAY · THIRD PARTIES AND SUPPLY CHAIN

A supplier's bank details are changed and the next payment run pays the fraudster

An outsider who has compromised a supplier's email requests a change of bank details, with a contact number in the request. When finance calls that number the fraudster confirms the change; sometimes a follow-up call in the usual contact's voice is enough.

The next genuine invoice is paid to the new account in the normal run. Every document is genuine, and because the monthly review of supplier payments does not yet run, nothing looks wrong until the real supplier asks why it has not been paid.

WARNING SIGNS

- A bank-detail change shortly before a large or scheduled payment
- A change request that arrives by email or from a new contact
- Pressure to make the change before the next payment run
- A supplier querying non-payment after a recent change

FIRST RESPONSE

Contact the bank immediately to recall or freeze the payment, confirm the correct details with the supplier through a number already on file, suspend further payments to the changed account and preserve the request and approval trail.

LASTING CONTROL

Every change to supplier bank details is confirmed with the supplier through contact details on file before it takes effect, by someone other than the person who captured it, whatever the caller appears to be.

FRAUD PATHWAY · THIRD PARTIES AND SUPPLY CHAIN

A purchase is split below the approval limit, and nobody looks across the orders

A buyer splits a purchase into orders that each fall below the approval limit, or a supplier resubmits an invoice already paid. Each transaction passes its own checks.

The pattern exists only in the payment data, which nobody examines while the senior review has not started and split orders are not monitored. The loss grows with each payment run until a supplier, an auditor or a whistle-blower raises it.

WARNING SIGNS

- Several orders to one supplier just below an approval limit
- Invoices with the same amount and supplier close together
- A supplier paid more often than its contract suggests
- Orders raised and received by the same person

FIRST RESPONSE

Stop further payments on the suspect orders or invoices, recover any duplicate payment from the supplier, and preserve the order, approval and payment records.

LASTING CONTROL

A senior manager who does not process payments reviews each month's supplier payments for splitting, duplicates, unfamiliar suppliers and changed bank details, and follows up each query.

WHAT MANAGEMENT SHOULD DO FIRST

Six controls come first, once the outstanding questions have owners

The first responses are the controls that close the findings above, in the order the work should start. They can be designed while the outstanding questions are being answered, because none of the questions concerns these controls directly. The full specification for each is in the supporting workbook.

FIRST RESPONSES

RESPONSE	ACCOUNTABLE EXECUTIVE	PRACTICAL OWNER	PROPOSED STAGE	SUCCESS MEASURE
Change confirmed with supplier	Chief financial officer	Finance lead	60 days	Every change to a supplier's bank details made in the period was confirmed with the supplier on contact details already on file before it took effect, or is a recorded and approved exception.
Familiar caller still verified	Chief financial officer	Finance lead	60 days	All staff who process changes to supplier details were briefed by the end of the period, and the most recent test found the rule followed in every case tested, including a call or video that appeared to come from the supplier's usual contact.
Senior review of supplier payments	Chief financial officer	Finance lead	60 days	The review of supplier payments ran monthly throughout the period, and every exception it raised has a recorded answer.
Application documents verified	Chief financial officer	Finance lead	60 days	Every credit application in the period has a credit application file showing the key information verified with its source before approval.
Block leave required	Chief financial officer	HR and payroll lead	60 days	Every person in a sensitive role in scope took a block of leave in the year with their work done by someone else, or has an approved exception.

RESPONSE	ACCOUNTABLE EXECUTIVE	PRACTICAL OWNER	PROPOSED STAGE	SUCCESS MEASURE
Customer detail changes verified	Chief financial officer	Commercial and customer lead	60 days	Every change to customer details in the period was verified with the customer through details already on file before it took effect, and was made by someone outside sales.

Responses are listed in the order the work should start, which is not a ranking of fraud risk. Stages are proposals for management's own plan, not deadlines. Full specifications, records and failure responses are in the supporting workbook.

Confirming every supplier bank change through details on file, and calling back on the number on file whatever a caller appears to be, together close the most practised route to payment fraud. The finance lead owns both, with the chief financial officer accountable.

Making the monthly senior review of supplier payments run gives the group its first view of payments as a whole, and verifying credit applications with their source closes the route that generated documents exploit. Both sit with the finance lead.

Block leave for every identified sensitive role, with cover by someone without conflicting duties, closes the route by which a long-running insider fraud is concealed. The HR and payroll lead owns it.

Verifying customer detail changes with the customer, and moving them out of sales, protects refunds and deliveries from redirection. The commercial and customer lead owns it.

A 30, 60 AND 90 DAY RESPONSE

The first ninety days close the information gaps, give each area an owner and put the first controls to work

The plan sets out three proposed stages. The windows are proposals for management’s own plan; they are not deadlines, contractual dates or estimates of how long any control takes to design or to prove. A control can be said to work only once it has met its success measure over a full operating cycle.

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS, IN PROPOSED STAGES

30 days

PROPOSED STAGE

Establish the facts, name the owners and decide the order of work.

- Every outstanding question answered, or an open item with an owner
- Each open area has a named accountable executive
- The order of work is recorded with the factors behind it

OWNERS

Every area owner, coordinated by the fraud risk lead and reporting to the chief executive

60 days

PROPOSED STAGE

Approve the design, owner and record for each priority control, and schedule its first operating cycle.

- Change confirmed with supplier
- Familiar caller still verified
- Senior review of supplier payments
- Application documents verified
- Block leave required
- Customer detail changes verified

OWNERS

Finance lead, HR and payroll lead, Commercial and customer lead

90 days

PROPOSED STAGE

Start operating the priority controls and report status to the oversight body.

- Each priority control has run at least once and kept its record
- Status reported to the board

OWNERS

Chief executive, Finance lead, HR and payroll lead, Commercial and customer lead

Windows are proposals for management's own plan. They are not deadlines, contractual dates or estimates of how long any control takes to design, put in place or show to be working. Every action, with its deliverable and completion test, is in the supporting workbook.

In the first thirty days, each outstanding question is assigned to a named person and either answered or recorded as an open item with an owner, the chief executive names an accountable executive for each operating area, and management records the order of work with the factors behind it. By sixty days, the priority controls have approved designs, owners and records. By ninety days, each has run at least once and the board has received a status report covering both the controls and the questions that remain open.

BASIS OF THIS REPORT

This report rests on the group's own answers, read against MK's method

Every finding rests on answers given by the group's respondent and the functions to which questions were referred. MK has not examined documents, interviewed staff or tested any control, and the records named in the report are records management should keep rather than evidence MK has reviewed. Independent examination of whether controls operate belongs to MK Advisory, which is scoped and priced separately.

Answers given as “not known” are reported as outstanding and are never treated as weaknesses or as controls in place; nothing in this report is concluded from them. Answers are also read together, under a reviewed table of relationships, so that a control reported in place is compared with the practices around it.

The position is stated in four parts with the executive summary: what was calculated, what is inconsistent, how the answers read and what MK concludes. Findings and responses are selected and ordered by the rules stated where they appear, not by a ranking of fraud risk.

PROTOTYPE NOTICE: WHAT A RELEASED REPORT ADDS

ELEMENT	IN A RELEASED REPORT	IN THIS EDITION
Readiness conclusion	Issued under MK's approved readiness method, with the score and level that method defines.	Calculated result shown as a labelled test fixture; no level or band issued (decision D-1).
Order of work	Set by MK's approved decision method.	Ordered by the explicit factors stated in the report, a candidate method (decision D-3).
Control specifications, pathways and decision options	MK-approved advisory content.	Draft content from MK's control-content library, scenario structures and decision options (decision D-5).
Manuscript	Written by the production AI writer from this fact pack, then validated.	Written in-session under the same writer contract and validated by the same checks; the production AI run is a blocked acceptance test.

MANAGEMENT CONCLUSION

The group should first learn what its own functions know, then carry its framework into the operations

The group should recognise two things about its position. Its fraud programme is complete at the centre and largely absent in the operating processes, and several of the functions that run those processes cannot say how some of their own controls work. Neither is unusual, but together they mean the group cannot yet see much of its own exposure.

A small number of changes will begin to close both gaps. Every outstanding question needs an owner and an answer. Every operating area needs an accountable executive. Changes to bank details, customer details and identity need to be verified through a route the requester does not control, and the monthly review of supplier payments needs to run.

Within ninety days, the outstanding questions should be answered or owned, each area should have an owner, the priority controls should be running, and the board should have a status report that shows what is now known and what has been closed.

Once the first controls are running, the sensible next step is to extend the work to the remaining scenarios in the order management has decided, and to arrange the independent examination of procurement and payroll that will show whether the new controls operate as designed.

Fraud strategy, readiness and operational resilience.

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This report was prepared for the management of Fictional Retail Group (extensive unanswered information) on the basis of the organisation's own answers to the MK Fraud Readiness assessment. It is confidential to the organisation. MK Fraud Insights is a trading name of Stonda (Pty) Ltd. Fictional prototype for MK review; not a customer report.